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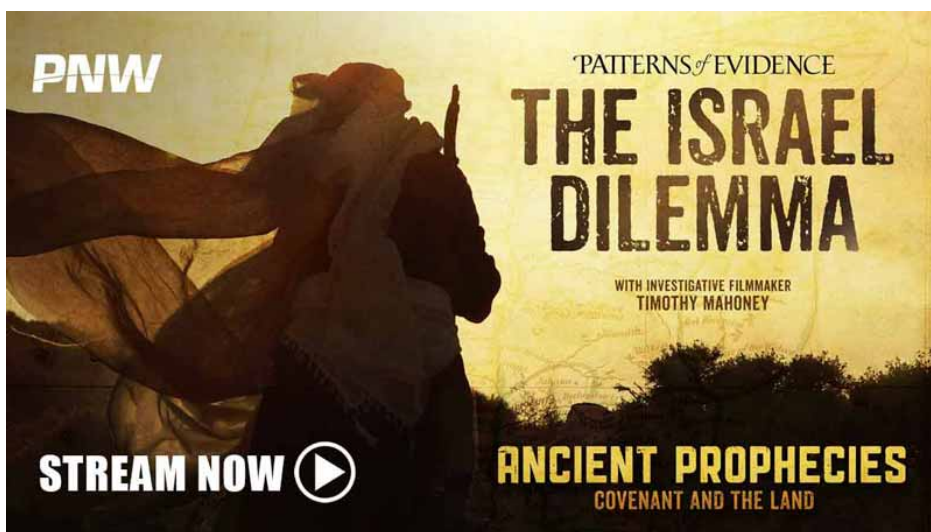
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ARTICLE

After Decades Of Debate, Scientists Are Finally Testing The Noah's Ark Site





BY PNW STAFF SEPTEMBER 25, 2026

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For decades, one of the most intriguing archaeological mysteries in the biblical world has been sitting in the mountains of eastern Turkey.

From the air, it looks remarkably like the outline of a massive ship.

Its length is approximately 515 feet. It sits in the region traditionally associated with Noah's Ark. Radar investigations have detected unusual linear features and voids beneath the surface. And researchers have spent years arguing over whether the Durupınar formation is simply an extraordinary geological coincidence — or the remains of something far more significant.

Now, for perhaps the first time, the argument is moving beyond photographs and radar screens.

Researchers have drilled deep inside the formation.

And almost immediately, they encountered something they weren't expecting.

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A Different Kind Of Ark Expedition

The 2026 investigation is significant because this is not simply another group of amateur Ark hunters walking across the mountains looking for pieces of wood.

The project is directed by Prof. Dr. Cenker Atila of the Department of Archaeology at Sivas Cumhuriyet University in cooperation with Noah's Ark Scans, and has received official authorization from Turkish authorities. The investigation includes GPS mapping, three-dimensional modeling, ground-penetrating radar, electrical-resistivity studies, soil sampling and now deep core drilling.

The Durupinar formation was identified from aerial photographs in 1959. Measuring approximately 157 meters — 515 feet — from end to end, its enormous boat-like outline has fascinated researchers ever since.

Genesis describes Noah's Ark as 300 cubits long. The precise length depends upon which ancient cubit measurement is used, but proponents have long argued that Durupinar falls strikingly close to plausible biblical dimensions.

More importantly, Genesis does not say the Ark landed on the summit of Mount Ararat.

It says the Ark rested "upon the mountains of Ararat."

Durupinar lies roughly 20 miles south of Mount Ararat, within that broader region.

For years, however, appearances could only take the argument so far.

Critics maintained that Durupinar was simply a natural geological formation.

So researchers finally decided to look underneath it.



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They Drilled Nearly 60 Feet Down

The current expedition has drilled both inside and outside the boat-shaped formation, recovering core samples from depths reaching approximately 18 meters — nearly 60 feet.

The comparison is important. Samples taken outside the formation can provide a geological control against which material recovered from inside can be tested.

According to the research team, the drilling has already produced an intriguing result: they report recovering organic-rich layers and encountering multiple underground cavities, while saying that the holes drilled inside the formation have so far failed to encounter the continuous solid limestone or bedrock some geological explanations would predict.

Then one drill hit something else.

At approximately four to five meters beneath the surface, after drilling through the overlying material, the equipment encountered an extremely hard layer.

The drill bit broke.

Researchers have raised the possibility that the material could be petrified or heavily mineralized wood.

But that distinction is important: they do not yet know what it is.

Samples are being sent for laboratory testing. Until those tests are completed, "petrified wood" remains a hypothesis rather than a discovery.

Yet even without knowing what broke the drill, what researchers are encountering underground is making Durupinar more interesting rather than less.

The Cavities May Be Even More Important

The broken drill bit makes a spectacular headline.



The underground spaces may ultimately prove more important.

Previous geophysical investigations reportedly detected linear features, right-angle intersections, elongated voids and anomalies that researchers have interpreted as possible corridors or chamber-like spaces.

Now drilling has physically encountered cavities beneath the formation. In at least one case, researchers reported penetrating a void containing mud and water.

That doesn't prove someone constructed those spaces. Natural geological processes can create cavities and unusual subsurface formations.

But it gives researchers something tangible to investigate.

And their next step could be fascinating.

They're Sending In A Robot

The team has developed a specialized underground exploration robot appropriately named GOPHER — a reference to the "gopher wood" mentioned in Genesis.

The small robotic system is designed to enter underground spaces through boreholes rather than requiring researchers to excavate huge sections of the site.

Its most important equipment may be remarkably simple:

A camera.

Researchers intend to send GOPHER into accessible voids identified through radar, electrical-resistivity studies and drilling. The robot carries a high-resolution camera capable of recording what actually exists inside those spaces.

Consider what that could mean.

Radar produces interpretations. Electrical measurements produce anomalies. Core samples provide narrow columns of material.

A camera potentially lets researchers see the interior.

If GOPHER encounters nothing but fractured rock, sediment and naturally formed cavities, that will be important evidence.

But if it encounters repeated geometric structures, walls, compartments, beams or other unmistakably artificial features, the Noah's Ark debate would enter an entirely different phase.

The Laboratory May Have The Final Word

The other major development will take place far away from Mount Ararat.

Researchers have collected extensive soil samples and core material that will undergo laboratory analysis. One account of the expedition reports approximately 1,000 soil samples from roughly 150 locations, with preliminary findings expected within months and a fuller report anticipated in 2027.

The project plans compositional, organic, mineralogical and stratigraphic testing, ultimately combining the results with radar, LiDAR, electrical surveys and other measurements to produce a detailed three-dimensional model of the formation.

This is where extraordinary claims finally meet measurable evidence.

If the supposedly organic layers turn out to be ordinary geological deposits, researchers will have to account for that.

If the exceptionally hard layer is ordinary stone, that will matter too.



But if laboratory testing identifies ancient wood or processed organic material where a natural geological model says it shouldn't be — particularly if it corresponds with geometric structures detected by radar — the implications would be difficult to dismiss.

And that is why the current investigation deserves attention.

What Happens If They Really Find Something?

Noah's Ark occupies an unusual place in modern culture.

Millions of people regard the Flood as historical. Others regard Genesis as theological mythology or a distant cultural memory built around ancient flooding events.

For generations, those two worlds have largely talked past one another.

Durupinar isn't going to settle every question surrounding Genesis.

But something different is happening there now.

For more than six decades, people have looked at this enormous boat-shaped formation and argued about what it might be. Researchers photographed it. They measured it. They scanned beneath it. Supporters saw a ship. Skeptics saw geology.

Now scientists are physically extracting what lies underneath.

They have encountered organic-rich layers.

They have encountered cavities.

They have encountered an extremely hard layer that broke their drilling equipment.

And soon they hope to put a camera inside some of those underground spaces.

None of this proves that Noah's Ark has been found.

But neither is Durupinar merely a curious shape on a mountainside anymore.

For the first time in decades, the mystery may be approaching a point where laboratory instruments, core samples and cameras can begin providing answers that arguments cannot.

And if those answers point toward an enormous man-made structure buried beneath the mountains of Ararat, one of the most famous accounts in the Bible could suddenly become one of the biggest archaeological stories of our time.

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